

0.0.1 Foremost Knowledge

1. Thus was heard by me. On one occasion the Auspicious One was dwelling in Savatthi at the Eastern Monastery, the mansion of Migara's Mother. At that time Vasettha and Bharadvaja were living on probation among the bhikkhus, wishing to become bhikkhus. Then in the evening, the Auspicious One, having emerged from seclusion, having descended from the palace, was walking up and down in the open air in the shade of the palace. Vasettha saw that the Auspicious One, having emerged from seclusion, having descended from the palace, was walking up and down in the open air in the shade of the palace. Having seen, he address Bharadvaja: "This Auspicious One, O friend Bharadvaja, having emerged from seclusion, having de-

aggaññasuttaṃ

evaṃ me sutam: ekaṃ samayaṃ bhagavā sāvatthiyaṃ viharati pubbārāme migāramātupāsāde. tena kho pana samayena vāsetṭhabhāradvājā bhikkhūsu parivāsanti¹ bhikkhubhāvaṃ ākaṅkhamānā. atha kho bhagavā sāyaṇhasamayaṃ paṭisallānā vuṭṭhito pāsādā orohitvā pāsādapacchāyāyaṃ² abbhokāse caṅkhamati. addasā kho vāsetṭho bhagavantam sāyaṇhasamayaṃ paṭisallānā vuṭṭhitam pāsādā orohitvā pāsādapacchāyāyaṃ abbhokāse caṅkhamantaṃ. disvāna bhāradvājaṃ āmanatesi: "ayaṃ āvuso bhāradvāja bhagavā

scended from the palace, is walking up and down in the open air in the shade of the palace. Let us approach this Auspicious One, O friend Bharadvaja. Hopefully, we might gain the hearing of a Dhamma talk in the presence of the Auspicious One.” “Yes, friend,” Bharadvaja replied to Vasettha. So then Vasettha and Bharadvaja approached the Auspicious One. Having approached, having bowed down to the Auspicious One, they walk back and forth following the Auspicious One.

2. Then the Auspicious One addressed Vasettha: “Here Vasettha, being brahmin by birth, of a brahmin caste, you

sāyaṇhasamayam paṭisallānā vuṭṭhito pāsādā orohitvā pāsādapacchāyāyaṃ abbhokāse caṅkamati. āyāmāvuso bhāradvāja yena bhagavā tenupasaṅkamissāma. appevaṇāma labheyyāma bhagavato santikā³ dhammiṃ katham savaṇāyā”ti. ‘evamāvuso’ti kho bhāradvājo vāseṭṭhassa paccassosi. atha kho vāseṭṭhabhāradvājā yena bhagavā tenu-pasaṅkamimṣu. upasaṅkamitvā bhagavantam abhivādetvā bhagavantam caṅkamantam anucaṅkamimṣu.

atha kho bhagavā vāseṭṭham āmantesi: ‘tumhe khvattha vāseṭṭhā, brāhmaṇajaccā brāhmaṇaku-

have gone forth from the home life into homelessness from a brahmin family. Hopefully, O Vasettha, the brahmins do not abuse you with verbal abuse.” “Certainly, O Bhante, the brahmins fully abuse and insult us with personally suitable verbal abuse without holding back.”

3. “But in which way, O Vasettha, do the brahmins fully abuse and insult you with personally suitable verbal abuse without holding back?” “The brahmins, O Bhante, say thus: “The brahmins are the only most excellent caste, other castes are inferior. The brahmins are the only bright caste, other castes are dark. The brahmins are the only well-born, not non-brahmins. The brahmins are the only legitimate sons of Brahma, born of his mouth,

līnā brāhmaṇakulā
agārasmā anagāri-
yaṃ pabbajitā. kacci
vo vāseṭṭhā, brāh-
maṇā na akkosanti
na paribhāsanti?ti.
“taggha no bhante,
brāhmaṇā akkosanti
paribhāsanti attarū-
pāya paribhāsāya
paripuṇṇāya no apa-
ripuṇṇāyā?ti”.

“yathā kathaṃ pana
vo vāseṭṭhā, brāh-
maṇā akkosanti pari-
bhāsanti attarūpāya
paribhāsāya paripuṇ-
ṇāya no aparipuṇ-
ṇāyā?ti”. brāhmaṇā
bhante evamāhaṃsu:
“brāhmaṇo’va seṭ-
ṭho vaṇṇo hīnā aññe
vaṇṇā brāhmaṇo’va
sukko vaṇṇo, kaṇhā
aññe vaṇṇā¹. brāh-
maṇā’va sujjhanti
no abrāhmaṇā brāh-
maṇā’va brahmuno
puttā orasā mukhato

born of Brahma, created by Brahma, an heir of Brahma. You, having abandoned the most excellent caste, have entered into an inferior caste, that of the shaven-headed counterfeit samanas, those dark menial offsprings of our kinsmen's feet. This is not good, this is not proper, that you, having abandoned the most excellent caste, have entered into an inferior caste, that of the shaven-headed counterfeit samanas, those dark menial offsprings of our kinsmen's feet." Thus do the brahmins fully abuse and insult us with personally suitable verbal abuse without holding back?"

4. Certainly, O Vasettha, the brahmins do not remember their ancestry when they say thus to you: "The brahmins

jātā brahmajā brahmanimmitā brahma-dāyādā. te tumhe seṭṭhaṃ vaṇṇaṃ hitvā hīnamattha vaṇṇaṃ ajjhupagatā, yadidaṃ muṇḍake samaṇake ibbhe kaṇhe bandhupādāpacce. tayidaṃ na sādhu, tayidaṃ nappaṭirūpaṃ, yaṃ tumhe seṭṭhaṃ vaṇṇaṃ hitvā hīnamattha vaṇṇaṃ ajjhupagatā, yadidaṃ muṇḍake samaṇake ibbhe kaṇhe bandhupādāpacce"ti. evaṃ kho no bhante brāhmaṇā akkosanti paribhāsanti attarūpāya paribhāsāya paripuṇṇāya no aparipuṇṇāyā"ti.

"taggha vo vāseṭṭhā brāhmaṇā porāṇaṃ asarantā evamāhaṃsu: brāhmaṇo'va seṭṭho vaṇṇo, hīnā

are the only most excellent caste, other castes are inferior. The brahmins are the only bright caste, other castes are dark. The brahmins are the only well-born, not non-brahmins. The brahmins are the only legitimate sons of Brahma, born of his mouth, born of Brahma, created by Brahma, an heir of Brahma.” Yet, O Vasettha, for the brahmins, the brahmin women are also seen menstruating, also being pregnant, also giving birth, also breastfeeding. Yet those brahmins, evidently being born from womb, say thus: The brahmins are the only most excellent caste, other castes are inferior. The brahmins are the only bright caste, other castes are dark. The brahmins are the only well-born, not non-brahmins. The brahmins are the only legitimate sons of Brahma, born of his mouth, born of Brahma, created by Brahma, an heir of Brahma.” Those

aññe vaṇṇā. brāhmaṇo va sukko vaṇṇo, kaṇhā aññe vaṇṇā, brāhmaṇā’va suj-jhanti no abrāhmaṇā, brāhmaṇā’va brahmuno puttā orasā mukhato jātā brāhmajā brahmanimitā brahmadāyādā”ti. dissanti kho pana vāsetṭhā brāhmaṇānaṃ brāhmaṇiyo utuniyo’pi gabbhiniyo’pi vijāyamānā’pi pāyamānā’pi. te ca brāhmaṇā yonijā’va samānā evamāhaṃsu: brāhmaṇo’va seṭṭho vaṇṇo -pe- puttā orasā -pe- brahmadāyādā”ti. te ca brahmaṇānceva abbhācikkhanti musā ca bhāsanti bahuñca apuññaṃ pasavanti.

brahmins simply misrepresent Brahma with untrue statements and accumulate much demerit.

5. There are, O Vasettha, these four castes, the Khattiya, the Brahmin, the Vessa and the Sudda. Here, O Vasettha, a certain khattiya is a killer of living beings, a taker of what is not given, an engager in misconduct in sensual pleasures, a speaker of falsehood, a speaker of divisive speech, a speaker of harsh speech, a covetous one, one with a mind of ill-will, a holder of wrong view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are unwholesome and reckoned as unwholesome, blameworthy and reckoned as blameworthy, not to be associated with and reckoned as not to be associated with, unsuitable for the noble ones and reckoned as unsuitable for the noble ones, dark

cattāro' me vāseṭṭha vaṇṇā, khattiyā brāhmaṇā vessā suddā. khattiyo'pi kho vāseṭṭhā, idhekacco paṇātipātī hoti adinnādāyī kāmesu micchācārī musāvādī piṣuṇavāco pharusavāco samphappalāpī abhiṇṇhālu byāpannacitto micchādiṭṭhī. iti kho vāseṭṭha, ye'me dhammā akusalā akusalasaṅkhātā sāvajjā sāvajjasaṅkhātā asevitabbā asevitabba-saṅkhātā na alamarīyā na alamariya-saṅkhātā, kaṇhā kaṇhahavipākā viññugarahitā, khattiye pi te idhekacce sandisanti. brāhmaṇo pi

with dark results, blamed by the wise, a khattiya is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain brahmin too is a killer of living beings, a taker of what is not given, an engager in misconduct in sensual pleasures, a speaker of falsehood, a speaker of divisive speech, a speaker of harsh speech, a covetous one, one with a mind of ill-will, a holder of wrong view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are unwholesome and reckoned as unwholesome, blameworthy and reckoned as blameworthy, not to be associated with and reckoned as not to be associated with, unsuitable for the noble ones and reckoned as unsuitable for the noble ones, dark with dark results, blamed by the wise, a brahmin too is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain vessa too is a killer of living beings, a taker of what is not given, an engager in misconduct in

kho vāseṭṭha -pe- vesso pi kho vāseṭṭha -pe- suddo pi kho vāseṭṭha idhekacco pāṇātipātī hoti adinnādāyī -pe- micchādiṭṭhī. iti kho vāseṭṭha, ye' me dhammā akusalā akusalasaṅkhātā -pe- kaṇhā kaṇhavipākā viññugarahitā, sudde pi te idhekacce sandisanti.

sensual pleasures, a speaker of falsehood, a speaker of divisive speech, a speaker of harsh speech, a covetous one, one with a mind of ill-will, a holder of wrong view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are unwholesome and reckoned as unwholesome, blameworthy and reckoned as blameworthy, not to be associated with and reckoned as not to be associated with, unsuitable for the noble ones and reckoned as unsuitable for the noble ones, dark with dark results, blamed by the wise, a vessa too is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain sudda too is a killer of living beings, a taker of what is not given, an engager in misconduct in sensual pleasures, a speaker of falsehood, a speaker of divisive speech, a speaker of harsh speech, a covetous one, one with a mind of ill-will, a holder of wrong view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas

which are unwholesome and reckoned as unwholesome, blameworthy and reckoned as blameworthy, not to be associated with and reckoned as not to be associated with, unsuitable for the noble ones and reckoned as unsuitable for the noble ones, dark with dark results, blamed by the wise, a sudda too is seen engaging in them.

6. Here, O Vasettha, a certain khattiya is an abstainer from the killing of living beings, an abstainer from the taking of what is not given, an abstainer from misconduct in sensual pleasures, an abstainer from false speech, an abstainer from divisive speech, an abstainer from harsh speech, an abstainer from senseless prattle, not covetous, one of a benevolent mind, one of right view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which

khattiyo pi kho vā-
setṭha, idhekacco pā-
ṇātipātā paṭivirato
hoti. adinnādānā
paṭivirato, kāmesu
micchācārā paṭivi-
rato, musāvādā paṭi-
virato, pisunāya vā-
cāya paṭivirato, pha-
rusāya vācāya paṭi-
virato, samphappa-
lāpā paṭivirato, ana-
bhijjhālu abyāpan-
nacitto sammādiṭ-
ṭhi. iti kho vāsetṭhā,
ye' me dhammā ku-
salā kusalasaṅkhātā

are wholesome and reckoned as wholesome, blameless and reckoned as blameless, to be associated with and reckoned as to be associated with, suitable for the noble ones and reckoned as suitable for the noble ones. bright with bright results, praised by the wise, a khattiya is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain brahmin too is an abstainer from the killing of living beings, an abstainer from the taking of what is not given, an abstainer from misconduct in sensual pleasures, an abstainer from false speech, an abstainer from divisive speech, an abstainer from harsh speech, an abstainer from senseless prattle, not covetous, one of a benevolent mind, one of right view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are wholesome and reckoned as wholesome, blameless and reckoned as blameless, to be associated with and reckoned

anavajjā anavajja-
saṅkhātā sevitaḅbā
sevitabbasaṅkhātā
alamariyā alamari-
yasaṅkhātā sukkā
sukkavipākā viññup-
pasatthā, khattiye
pi te vāseṭṭhā idhe-
kacce sandissanti.
brāhmaṇo pi kho
vāseṭṭhā, -pe- vesso
pi kho vāseṭṭhā -pe-
suddo pi kho vāseṭ-
ṭhā idhekacco pāṇā-
tipātā paṭivirato hoti
-pe- anabhijjhālu
abyāpannacitto sam-
māditṭhi. iti kho vā-
seṭṭhā, ye’me dhammā
kusalā kusalasaṅ-
khātā anavajjā ana-
vajjasāṅkhātā se-
vitabbā sevitaḅba-
saṅkhātā alamariyā
alamariyasaṅkhātā
sukkā sukkavipākā
viññuppasatthā,¹
suddepi te idhekacce
sandissanti.

as to be associated with, suitable for the noble ones and reckoned as suitable for the noble ones, bright with bright results, praised by the wise, a brahmin is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain vessa too is an abstainer from the killing of living beings, an abstainer from the taking of what is not given, an abstainer from misconduct in sensual pleasures, an abstainer from false speech, an abstainer from divisive speech, an abstainer from harsh speech, an abstainer from senseless prattle, not covetous, one of a benevolent mind, one of right view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are wholesome and reckoned as wholesome, blameless and reckoned as blameless, to be associated with and reckoned as to be associated with, suitable for the noble ones and reckoned as suitable for the noble ones, bright with bright

results, praised by the wise, a vessa is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain sudda too is an abstainer from the killing of living beings, an abstainer from the taking of what is not given, an abstainer from misconduct in sensual pleasures, an abstainer from false speech, an abstainer from divisive speech, an abstainer from harsh speech, an abstainer from senseless prattle, not covetous, one of a benevolent mind, one of right view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are wholesome and reckoned as wholesome, blameless and reckoned as blameless, to be associated with and reckoned as to be associated with, suitable for the noble ones and reckoned as suitable for the noble ones, bright with bright results, praised by the wise, a sudda is seen engaging in them.

7. With both dark and bright dhammas existing thus, O Vasettha, both-ways mixed among these four castes, [both what is] blamed by the wise and praised by the wise, of which here the brahmins say thus: “The brahmins are the only most excellent caste, other castes are inferior. The brahmins are the only bright caste, other castes are dark. The brahmins are the only well-born, not non-brahmins. The brahmins are the only legitimate sons of Brahma, born of his mouth, born of Brahma, created by Brahma, an heir of Brahma.” that the wise do not agree. What is the reason for that? Because, O Vasettha, whichever bhikkhu of the four castes is an arahant with asavas extincted, one who has lived [the life of purity], done what must be done, laid down the burden, attained the true advantage, completely extincted the fetters of being,

imesu kho vāseṭṭhā, catusu vaṇṇesu evaṃ ubhayavokiṇṇesu vattamānesu kaṇhasukkesu dhammesu viññugarahitesu ceva viññupapatthesu ca. ya-dettha brāhmaṇā evamāhaṃsu: brāhmaṇo’va seṭṭho vaṇṇo hīnā aññe vaṇṇā. brāhmaṇo’va sukko vaṇṇo kaṇhā aññe vaṇṇā, brāhmaṇā’va sujjhanti no abrāhmaṇā, brāhmaṇā’va brahmuno puttā orasā mukhato jātā brahmajā brahmanimmitā brahmadāyādā”ti. taṃ tesam viññū nānujānanti. taṃ kissa hetu? imesaṃ hi vāseṭṭhā, catunnaṃ vaṇṇānaṃ yo hoti bhikkhu arahamaṃ khīṇāsavo vusitavā katakaraṇīyo ohitabhāro anup-

one who is liberated by right final knowledge, he is said to be the foremost of them according to Dhamma, not non-Dhamma. Indeed Dhamma, O Vasetthā, is simply the best cause of birth in this world and the next.

8. By this method, O Vasettha, it is to be known how the Dhamma is simply the best cause of birth in this world and the next. King Pasenadi of Kosala knows well, O Vasettha: “The samana Gotama who has gone forth from a Sakyan family, is superior.” But the Sakyans, O vāseṭṭhā, exist as subordinate followers of King Pasenadi of Kosala. They, the Sakyans, O Vasettha, perform acts of submission to King Pasenadi of Kosala, bowing down, rising from their seats [as a

pattasadattho parikkhīṇabhavasam-yojano sammadaññāvimutto, so nesam² aggamakkhāyati. dhammeneva no adhammena. dhammo hi vāseṭṭhā seṭṭho janetasmim diṭṭhe ceva dhamme abhisamparāyeca³.

tadamināpetam vāseṭṭhā, pariyāyena veditabbam yathā dhammova seṭṭho janetasmim diṭṭhe ceva dhamme abhisamparāye¹ca. jānāti kho pana vāseṭṭhā, rājā pasenadi kosalo “samaṇo gotamo anuttaro sakyakulā pabbajito”ti. sakyā kho pana vāseṭṭhā, rañño pasenadino kosalassa anantarā anuyuttā bhavanti. karonti kho vāseṭṭhā, sakyā

token of respect], doing reverential salutations and paying homage. Thus, O Vasettha, those acts of submission which they, the Sakyans, perform to King Pasenadi of Kosala, bowing down, rising from their seats [as a token of respect], doing reverential salutations and paying homage, it is those [same acts] that King Pasenadi of Kosala, perform towards the Tathagata, bowing down, rising from his seat [as a token of respect], doing reverential salutations and paying homage, [thinking]: “Certainly the samana Gotama is well-born, while I am ill-born, the samana Gotama is powerful, while I am powerless, the samana Gotama is elegant, while I am ugly, the samana Gotama is of great influence, while I am of little influence.” Now for him it is only by honoring the Dhamma, respecting the Dhamma, revering the Dhamma, wor-

raññe pasenadimhi kosale nipaccakāram abhivādanam paccuṭṭhānam añjalikammaṃ sāmīcikkammaṃ. iti kho vāsetṭhā, yaṃ karonti sakyā raññe pasenadimhi kosale nipaccakāram abhivādanam paccuṭṭhānam añjalikammaṃ sāmīcikkammaṃ, karoti taṃ rājā pasenadi kosalo tathāgate nipaccakāram abhivādanam paccuṭṭhānam añjalikammaṃ sāmīcikkammaṃ. nanu² ‘sujāto samaṇo gotamo, dujjāto³ hamasmi, balavā samaṇo gotamo dubbalo’hamasmi, pāsādikō samaṇo gotamo dubbaṇṇo’hamasmi, mahesakkhō samaṇo gotamo, appesakkhō’hamasmī”ti.

shipping the Dhamma, esteeming the Dhamma, that King Pasenadi of Kosala, perform such acts of submission towards the Tathagata, bowing down, rising from his seat [as a token of respect], doing reverential salutations and paying homage.

9. By this method too, O Vasettha, it is to be known how the Dhamma is simply the best cause of birth in this world and the next. All of you here, O Vasettha, of various births, various names, various lineages, various families, have gone forth from home life into homelessness. When being asked: “Who are you?” you should acknowledge: “We are samanas, sons of the Sakyan.” Of whom, O Vasettha, faith in the Tatha-

atha kho naṃ dhammaṃ yeva sakkaronto dhammaṃ garukaronto dhammaṃ mānento dhammaṃ pūjento dhammaṃ apacāyamāno evaṃ rājā pasenadi kosalo tathāgate nipaccakāraṃ karoti abhivādanaṃ paccuṭṭhānaṃ añjalikammaṃ sāmīcikkammaṃ.

iminā’pi kho etaṃ vāseṭṭhā, pariyāyena veditabbaṃ yathā dhammo’va seṭṭho jane’tasmiṃ diṭṭhe ceva dhamme abhisamparāye1ca. tumhe khvattha vāseṭṭhā nānājaccā nānānāmā nānāgottā nānākulā agārasmā anagāriyaṃ pabbajitā. ‘ke tumhe?’ti puṭṭhā samānā, ‘samaṇā sakyaputtiyamhā’ti paṭijānātha. yassa

gata is settled, rooted, established, firm, unshakeable by any samana or brahmana or deva or mara or Brahma or anyone in the world, this is fitting for him to say: “I am truly the legitimate son of the Auspicious One, born of his mouth, born of the Dhamma, created by the Dhamma, an heir of the Dhamma.” What is the reason for that? Because, O Vasettha, this is the designation for the Tathagata: “An embodiment of Dhamma.” Also “An embodiment of Brahma.” Also “A Dhamma Being.” Also “A Brahma Being.”

kho panassa vāseṭṭhā, tathāgate saddhā nivīṭṭhā mūlajātā patitṭhitā dāḷhā asaṃhāriyā⁴ samāṇena vā brāhmaṇena vā devena vā mārena vā brahmunā vā kenaci vā lokasmiṃ, tassetam kalam vacanāya: bhagavato’ mhi putto oraso mukhato jāto dhammajo dhammanimmito dhammādāyādo’ ti. tam kissa hetu? tathāgatassa hetam vāseṭṭhā adhi vacanam dhammakāyo iti pi, brahmakāyo iti pi, dhammabhūto iti pi, brahmaphūto iti pi.

